University of BRISTOL

Getting the grades

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Getting to know you

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Who are you? All yr12? (No sneaky yr11s trying to get a head start).
South West? Hands up – Bristol, Somerset, Gloucestershire, Wales, …?
Some personal questions – eyes closed hands up, or thumbs up/down. Unsure, wavy hand. No peeking.
Hands up, planning on applying to uni?
Today applicable to all, any route. But personal interest: hands up, anyone planning on applying to Univ of Bristol?
Thumbs up/down/middle: how are current studies going?
Hands up: who feels like they're nailing it?
Hands up: who feels a bit out of their depth?

Born in Gloucester, school in Devon, uni in Bristol.
First in my family to come to University. Very supportive. Very proud when I graduated.
Trained to teach with Teach First, taught in London.
Helped set up a new Academy.
Came back to Bristol for a PhD. Graduated again – alongside a student I taught in yr7! Graduation is fun, parents proud again.
Now do research into drones and renewable energy. Prog Dir for Aero. WP Officer for Eng. Involved with admissions, support of students in transition to university and throughout course.
Also do fun and sometimes silly science things outside of work – eg a play in a camper van at a festival under a giant space telescope, and a podcast called The Cosmic Shed.

The plan

- Getting to know each other ✅
- The good, the bad and the ugly
- Knowledge, skills, and habits
- Planning: backwards and forwards

30 min + questions

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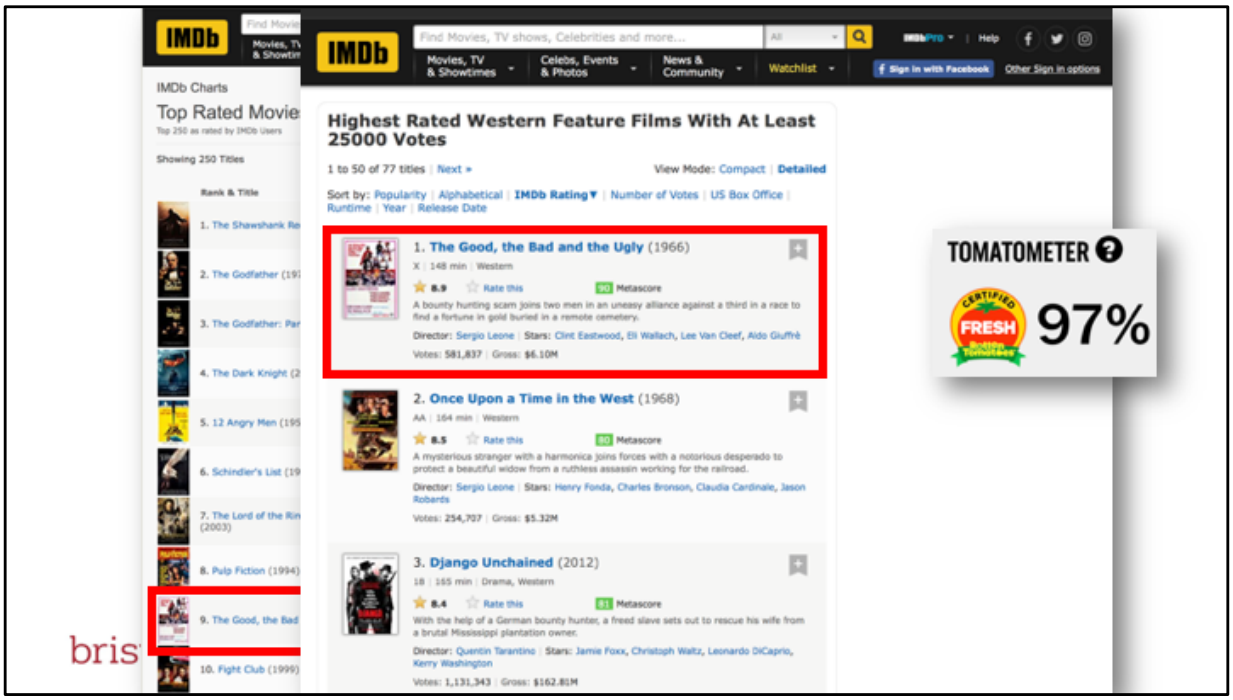
The plan. Done item 1. 30 min, time for questions afterwards.
But first – have you heard this phrase before? Where does it come from?
Shame/well done – for those of you who don't… if there's only one thing you take away from this today…



Watch this film. 9th best film EVER (actually I'm not a huge fan of 12 Angry Men). BEST western ever. Certified FRESH.
You'll probably recognise the theme tune…

Right time in your studies to be thinking about this. More independence in 6th form, getting to know your preferences and habits. You're planning and looking forward to uni applications, finals etc.

Unfortunately, I don’t have a magic wand. If I did, I still wouldn’t use it… the experiences you’ll go through in the next year will determine a lot about your future.

No pressure. Actually, pressure. But we'll talk a bit later about channelling it.

Grades matter

- To clarify: **you are not a number,** but…
- Evidence of your achievement
  - Understanding
  - Ability to learn
  - Work ethic, habits
- First-pass filter is necessary

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Grades matter. I don't think exams are a particularly good way of assessing real-world skills, but unfortunately they're a fact of life at various stages of studies. 'Least worst' way we've got of assessing at scale.
To clarify – not suggesting that they're the only thing that matters. No way.
Definitely true for uni, even more true for life.
But 10,000 applications a year means first-pass filter has to be on data.

The bright side

- Now is a great time to consider this
- Skills and habits you develop now will set you up for
  - A-levels etc.
  - University
  - Employment
  - Life
- Worth putting time and energy in

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Getting the grades

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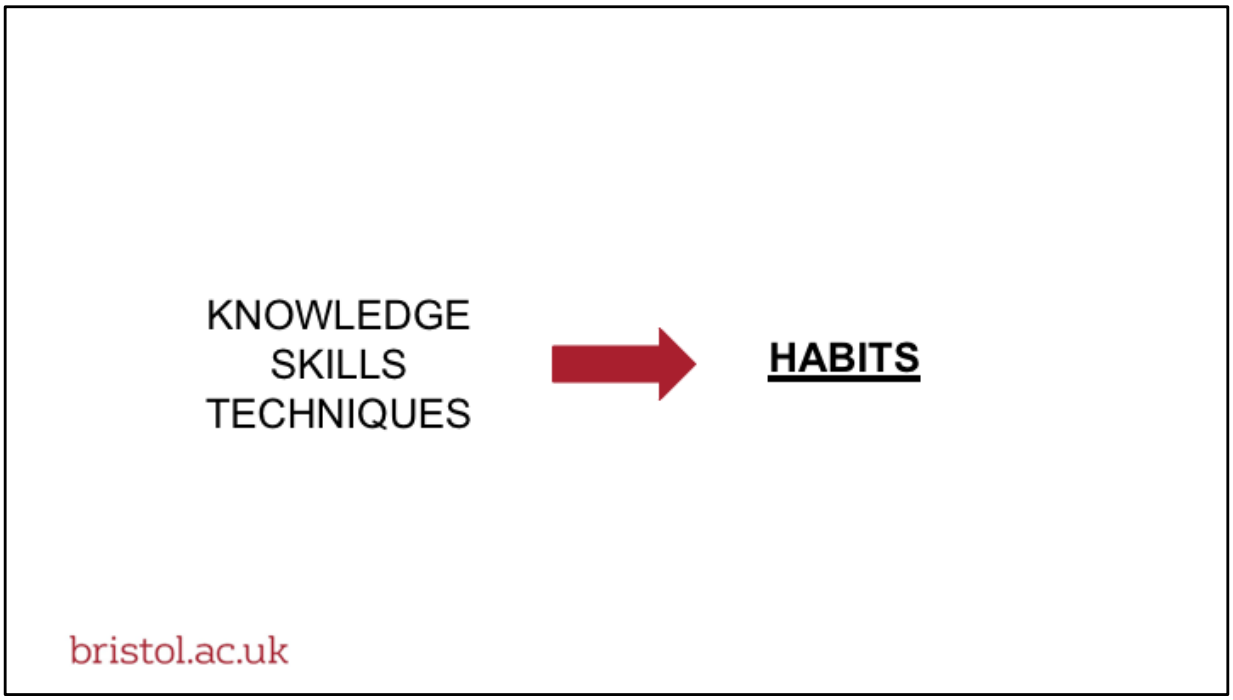
Here’s what you came for.



I'm going to cover a few of these, and tell you how to find out more.
We can talk about them all day, but it's up to you to embed them in your learning.
Everyone's different, so pick and mix.
You may think that some are just common sense, but it's surprising how easy it is to lose that when you're deep in your studies.

Getting the grades

1. Efficient learning
2. Time management
3. Sticking to goals

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Lots and lots of different tools.
I'm going to give you my top 3.

1. Efficient learning

- What do I need to know?
- How can I get it inside my head *fast*?
- How can I keep it inside my head?
- How can I nail my assessments?

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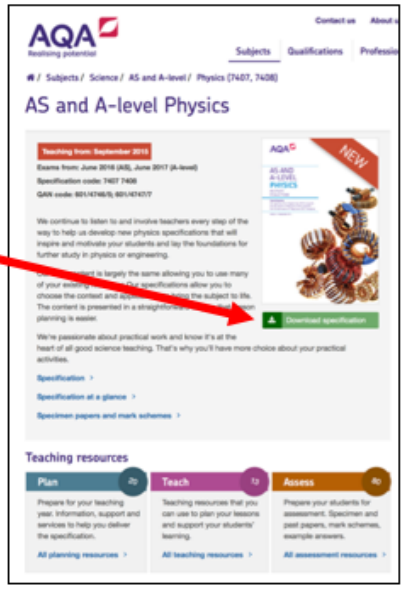
Specification
Knowledge absorption
Knowledge retention
Skills and speed, past papers

1. Efficient learning

- What do I need to know?
  - Exam board specification



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Whose teachers show them these?
Some do, some don't.
I highly recommend.

1. Efficient learning

- How can I get it inside my head *fast*?
- How can I keep it inside my head?

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Down to neurology and psychology.
I'm not an expert – I'm simplifying things I've had simplified for me.
If you're doing Psych A-level and I tell you anything that disagrees with what your teacher says – they're right.

Cornell notes

- One way of laying out notes
  - A process
  - Encourages recap/review
  - End up with good revision notes
  - Good learning neuroscience
- Try it, or find what works for you

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2 1/2"	6"
Cue Column	Note-taking Column

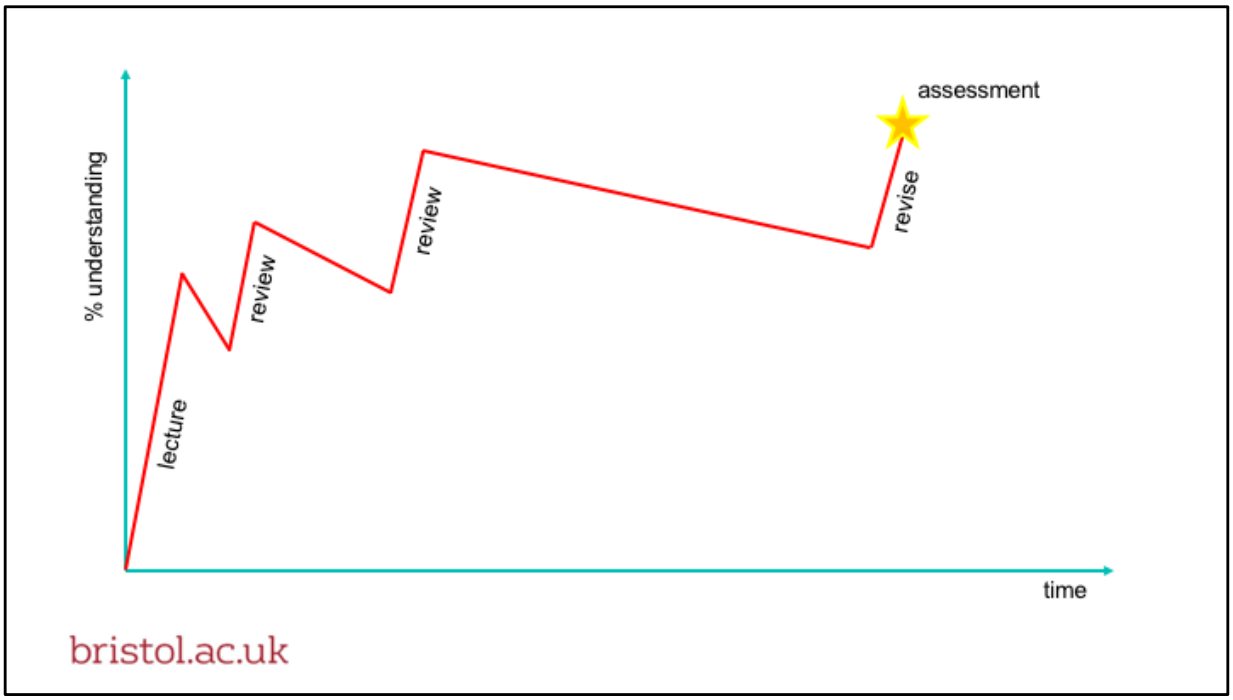
1. **Record**: During the lecture, use the note-taking column to record the lecture using telegraphic sentences.
2. **Questions**: As soon after class as possible, formulate questions based on the notes in the right-hand column. Writing questions helps to clarify meanings, reveal relationships, establish continuity, and strengthen memory. Also, the writing of questions sets up a perfect stage for exam-studying later.
3. **Recite**: Cover the note-taking column with a sheet of paper. Then, looking at the questions or cue-words in the question and cue column only, say aloud, in your own words, the answers to the questions, facts, or ideas indicated by the cue-words.
4. **Reflect**: Reflect on the material by asking yourself questions, for example: "What's the significance of these facts? What principle are they based on? How can I apply them? How do they fit in with what I already know? What's beyond them?
5. **Review**: Spend at least ten minutes every week reviewing all your previous notes. If you do, you'll retain a great deal for current use, as well as, for the exam.

Summary

2"

After class, use this space at the bottom of each page to summarize the notes on that page.

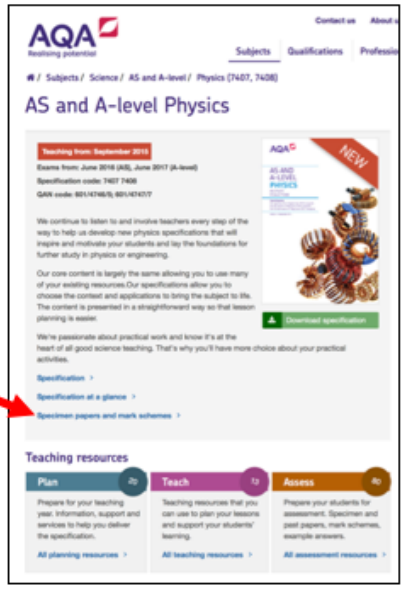
Adapted from How to Study in College 7/e by Walter Pauk, 2001 Houghton Mifflin Company



Review regularly – reinforce neural pathways.

1. Efficient learning

- How can I nail my assessments?
  - Repeat repeat repeat
  - Get *fast*
  - Treat past papers like gold



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colour 1: timed paper, exam conditions
colour 2: extra time, exam conditions
colour 3: correct BEFORE marking (use notes/textbook)
colour 4: mark and correct
Then focus revision on relevant content/speed.

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Coloured pens are your friend.

2. Time management

- Big picture
  - What time do I have available?
  - What are my other commitments?
  - How do I want to work?
  - What's coming up?
  - Where are my crunch times?
  - When can I ~~slack off~~ look after myself?
- Scheduling
  - Lay out your week/day
  - Spot the opportunities
  - Create habits and routines

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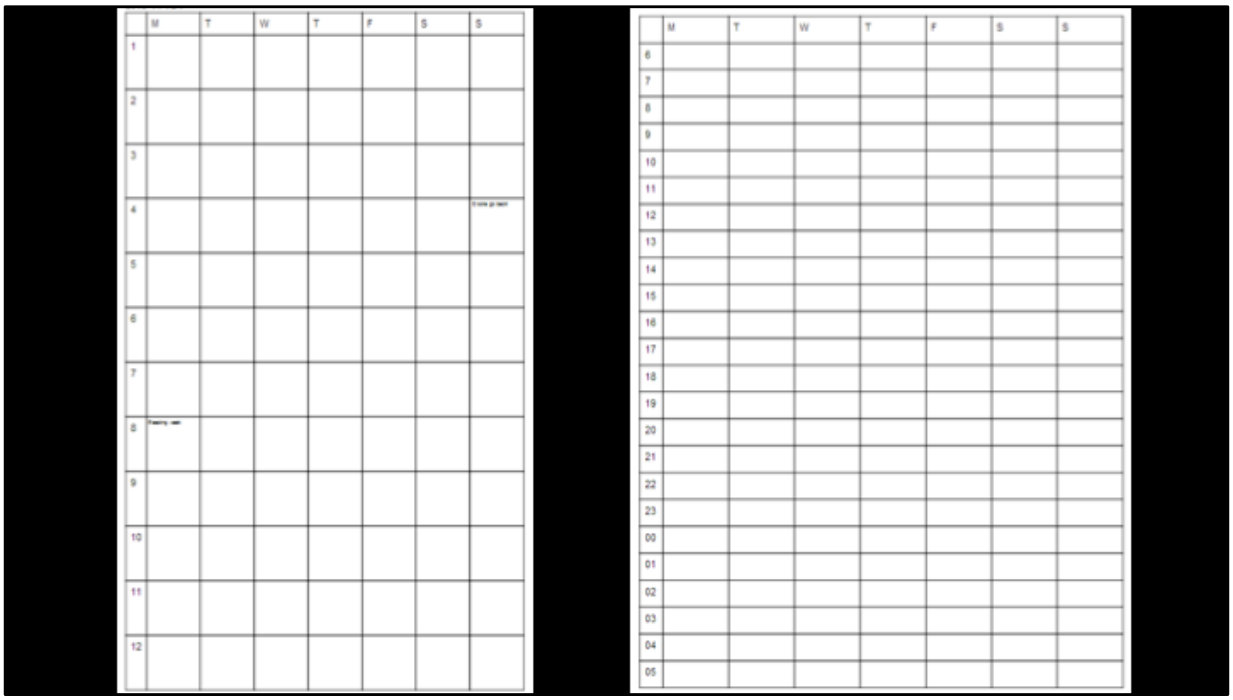

Like a revision timetable, but for the whole year. LEARNING, not revision.
It's ok to take breaks. Hols, project weeks, trips… plan it in
Daily routine – sleep, eat, socialise, game, Facebook… plan it in
Identify 'odds and ends' e.g. time you can use rather than waste.

3. Sticking to goals

- Easy to set, hard to stick to?
  - Accountability (to self or to others)
  - Positive reinforcement – what is your reward pattern?
  - Be kind but firm

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The one I find the hardest.
Easy to set, hard to stick to.
Accountability – self/friends
Trick yourself – positive reinforcement. What does constructive/destructive reinforcement look like?
Be kind to yourself, but consider how firm.
Channel stress and pressure.

3. Sticking to goals

- Create good, strong, clear goals
- Write them down
- Refer to them
- Motivate yourself

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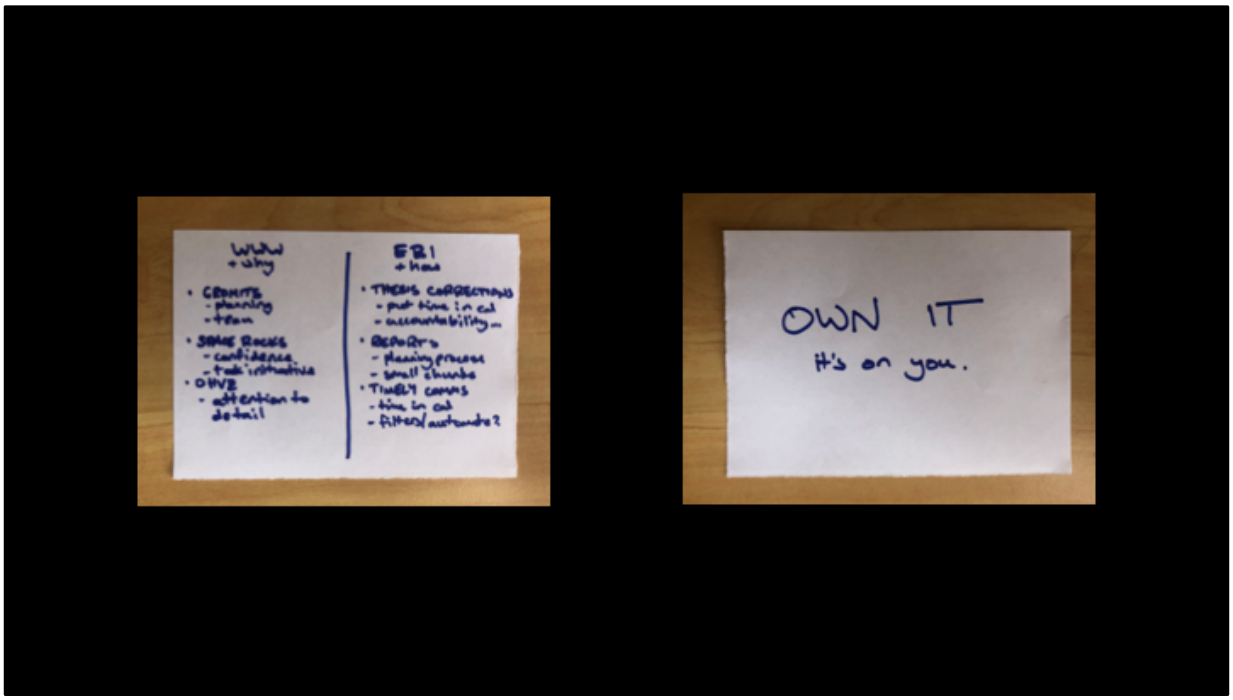

Small goal-setting exercise.
What went well (and why)
Even better if (and how)
Motivating note on other side.
I'll take (and mail to you in a few weeks, if you like), or you keep.

Final words…

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Wanted to come up with something inspiring, but basically it's all on you. You have time, hopefully you now have some ideas of how to make the most of it. Use teachers, family, friends etc. Good luck, but you won't need it if you follow my advice and OWN IT.

Like this guy.

University of BRISTOL

Thanks

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